



to Fight Deployment of Flock and Other Mass Surveillance License Plate Readers in Your Community

The ACLU provides a range of tactics for communities to stop or limit the use of Flock's ALPR mass surveillance technology

Chad Marlow, Senior Policy Counsel, ACLU

Jay Stanley, Senior Policy Analyst, ACLU Speech, Privacy, and Technology Project

Tracking ALPR Cameras News Series

June 29, 2026

The ACLU provides a range of tactics for communities to stop or limit the use of Flock's ALPR mass surveillance technology

Americans across the country have objected the privacy invasion of the infamous mass surveillance company Flock Safety as a nationwide movement has emerged to oppose local partnerships with Flock.

Advocates and local officials from across the political spectrum have helped push cities [across the U.S.](#) to terminate their contracts with the company. Many recoiled learning that the company was sharing local automated license plate reader (ALPR) data with U.S. Immigration and Customs Enforcement (ICE) to assist with deportation efforts. One Texas sheriff even used that data to track down a woman who'd had an abortion. A federal law enforcement agency also used the readers to identify attendees at a gun show.

More than 55 localities have ended contracts with Flock in the past year alone. If your city or town is already doing ALPR business with Flock or one of its competitors, Axon or Motorola Solutions, we encourage you to join this movement to [terminate your local government's relationship with the company](#). And if police or government leaders are currently pushing for a mass-surveillance ALPR system in your community, we urge you to oppose it.

In some cities, opponents of ALPRs have had a difficult time winning an outright rejection of this technology. We offer a suite of options below for limiting the dangers

and damage of such a system. If you live in a community where ALPR systems can't be stopped entirely, you can still help protect your neighborhood's civil liberties. We recommend working with your local police department and elected officials to ensure that local ALPR cameras do not feed into a mass surveillance system that lets potentially every law enforcement department in the world spy on any city in the U.S.

What is Flock Doing?

Flock says its corporate objective is to build a national camera network of ALPRs by placing them in every city in the United States. While license plate readers have been around for some time, Flock and its venture capital investors are pursuing massive profits by increasing the government's ability to identify and track vehicles and drivers in local communities to dystopian levels. As Flock itself [boasts](#), its nationwide ALPR network produces more than 20 billion vehicle-tracking plate scans every month in more than 5,000 American communities.

Flock not only allows private camera owners to create their own "hot lists" that will generate alarms when listed plates are spotted, it also [runs all plates](#) against larger state police watchlists and the FBI's primary criminal database, the National Crime Information Center (NCIC). Flock works with police departments, neighborhood watch groups, and other private customers.

Unlike a targeted ALPR camera system that is designed to take pictures of license plates, check the plates against local hot lists, and then flush the data if there's no hit, Flock is [building](#) a giant camera network that records people's comings and goings across the nation. It then makes that data available for any of its law enforcement customers. A current Flock law enforcement customer can also run a search on behalf of other agencies, like ICE. This provides even small-town sheriffs access to a sweeping and powerful mass-surveillance tool. Big actors like federal agencies and large urban police departments can also access the comings and goings of vehicles in even the smallest of towns. Both [Axon](#) and [Motorola Solutions](#), who are competitors to Flock, are pursuing similar business models.

Many police departments neither understand nor endorse Flock mass surveillance-driven approach but are using the company's cameras simply because other police departments in their region are doing so. For example, the police department in Syracuse [inadvertently shared its local ALPR data](#) via Flock's nationwide system, allowing their data to be searched 4.4 million times in a single year. Syracuse cancelled its Flock contract once this information came to light. Syracuse's story is not an outlier, it has happened to police departments nationwide. Your own police department may also be amenable to compromise. That might include using a vendor that does not tie its cameras into a mass-surveillance system. In other cases, you may be able to get your police department or local legislators to add provisions to Flock's standard contract that limit its mass surveillance and data sharing capabilities.

If your city or state insists on using ALPRs, the ACLU has model bills you can ask your [state](#) and [local](#) legislators to adopt to ensure guardrails for critical civil rights and

liberties are put into law before ALPRs are placed in the field. You can do this by urging your state and local representatives to adopt our recommendations, attending public meetings and hearings, and raising awareness by writing letters to the editor and op-eds. You can also use social media to highlight the issues. Be sure to tag your elected officials with #GetTheFlockOut.

The three most important areas for regulation and negotiation are how long the ALPR data is retained, who the ALPR data is shared with, and how ALPRs and their data are used by law enforcement. We obtained samples of Flock's Government Agency Customer Agreements with the Greensboro, North Carolina Police Department and other Flock contracts with local police. Below is suggested contract language across these three areas, based on these agreements, that you can use in your local advocacy efforts.

Data Retention

Whether ALPRs are being used for Amber Alerts, toll collection, or to identify stolen vehicles, agencies can run a license plate against a watchlist in seconds. The police do not need records of every person's comings and goings, including trips to doctor's offices, religious institutions, and political gatherings.

New Hampshire [state law](#) is a good model. It requires law enforcement to delete license plate data that is not connected to a crime within three minutes. But you should get the shortest retention period you can in your community. From worst to best, here are three approaches that can be taken to the retention of ALPR data:

Who Has Access to the Data?

One of the most important privacy steps you can take is to restrict your community's ALPR system to local use. That means local ALPR scans only check locally developed watch lists. Allowing local ALPR data to be used by outside law enforcement creates significant risks. Your local ALPR data could be used to enforce anti-abortion or anti-immigrant laws from other jurisdictions. It could even assist foreign, authoritarian regimes in hunting down political opponents and refugees living in America. Flock's default provisions give the company a "worldwide" license to use its customers' ALPR data.

These risks are simply not worth taking, especially since there are many other companies that sell locally focused systems. From worst to best, here are three data sharing and use approaches:

Database Use

As much as we might hope that all police watchlists were fully reliable, we know they are not. In fact, the FBI's criminal database, the largest and most used national watch list, does not even comply with the [1974 United States Privacy Act's](#) basic accuracy, reliability, and completeness requirements. That means allowing your ALPR data to be run against such databases will subject anyone living in or visiting your town to the risk of unjustified arrest and detention. This is an especially dangerous proposition for members of vulnerable, overpoliced communities. Here are three database use approaches, from worst to best:

Neither local police departments, government officials, nor residents should accept Flock's model. We continue to believe that using Flock cameras, or cameras from its competitors Axon or Motorola, [should be opposed outright](#). But where that battle can't be won, any system should at least be confined to the community itself and not be part of a national and international mass-surveillance system.

Learn More About the Issues on This Page

[Privacy & Technology](#)

[Automatic License Plate Readers](#)

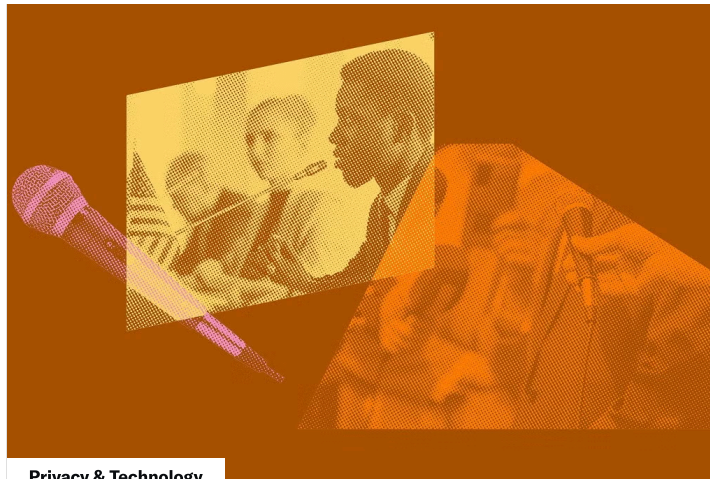
[Surveillance Technologies](#)

[Location Tracking](#)

Related Content

Press Release

Jun 2026



Privacy & Technology

ACLU Applauds Important Supreme Court Decision Making Clear Location Data is Protected by the Constitution

WASHINGTON — The Supreme Court held today that a dragnet search using Google's location history data is covered by the Fourth Amendment's protections against unreasonable search and seizures. The decision forcefully rejected the government's argument that law enforcement can request our location data in the form of a "geofence" search free of any Fourth Amendment limitation. The geofence search at issue in the case is an invasive surveillance technique that enables police to search for and locate unknown numbers of people in a large geographical area by exploiting cell phone location data held by Google. "The Court's decision provides critical protection against invasive and overbroad government searches of our personal information," said Brett Max Kaufman, senior counsel with ACLU's Center for Democracy. "Although Google already changed its system so it no longer has access to the same data the government had been seeking through geofence warrants, similar kinds of reverse searches of sensitive data held by other companies will continue to be a threat to privacy. Law enforcement and courts are on notice that new technology does not open up surveillance loopholes, and strict adherence to the Fourth Amendment's protections is required." In the five-justice majority opinion, Supreme Court Justice Elena Kagan compared the geofence search of Google location history to the cell site location information (CSLI) at issue in the landmark 2018 decision in *Carpenter v. United States*, an ACLU case. Justice Kagan wrote, "Location History implicates personal privacy interests even more than CSLI, because Location History is more the cell-phone user's own. Most cell-phone users have no awareness of CSLI records, and would never try to retrieve them; by contrast, Google users regularly employ Location History as a personal journal. In that way, Location History resembles other private materials—e.g., emails, documents, photographs, or calendars—that even if stored on Google's servers, a user reasonably views as his own and expects to be shielded from the "inquisitive eyes" of the government." Separately, Justice Gorsuch also rejected the government's argument, concluding that a geofence search violates an individual's right to personal property. Three justices dissented. Geofence warrants direct Google or other companies to hand over users' location data from cell phones and other mobile devices the company estimates were in a certain area during a certain time frame — regardless of whether police demonstrate that they had reason to believe the people who own these devices were involved in any crime. A high-level analysis conducted by ACLU of Northern California of the types of places captured by law enforcement in geofence warrants across San Francisco, for instance, revealed a troubling pattern of broad searches that swept in many people with no connection to the crime, including

at their homes and other constitutionally-protected spaces. The American Civil Liberties Union, the ACLU of Virginia, Electronic Frontier Foundation, and the Center on Privacy & Technology at Georgetown Law filed an amicus brief in this case, arguing that these geofence searches implicate core Fourth Amendment concerns, and that police should not be able to conduct searches using geofence warrants because they sweep in people as to whom the government has no reason to believe they were engaged in criminal conduct. As the groups explained, a search that ensnares any number of innocent people just because they are nearby when a crime occurs is an unconstitutional fishing expedition that violates the Constitution. "The Court's decision confirms that law enforcement does not have a blank check to use new technology to conduct warrantless surveillance of people's movements," said Eden Heilman, legal director of the ACLU of Virginia. "We do not lose our right to privacy simply because we use a cellphone." In its decision today, the Court held that a government request for any amount of cell phone location history is a search under the Fourth Amendment and thus requires a warrant. The Court left it to the lower courts, on remand, to assess whether the warrant that the government obtained in this case complies with Fourth Amendment requirements. The ACLU's amicus brief in *United States v. Chatrue* is part of the Joan and Irwin Jacobs Supreme Court docket.

Court Case: United States v. Chatrue

Affiliate: Virginia

News & Commentary

Jun 2026

Free FUTURE



Privacy & Technology Criminal Law Reform

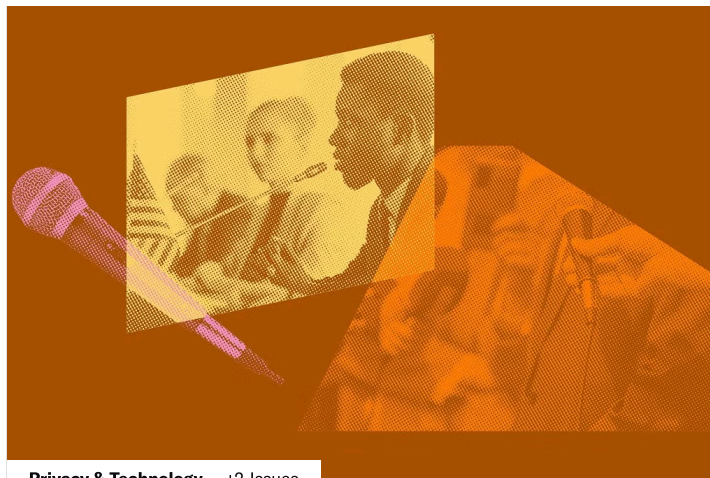
Surveillance is Driving a Corporatization of Police Departments

What are the implications of having for-profit companies at the heart of American police departments?

By: Jay Stanley

Press Release

Jun 2026



Privacy & Technology +2 Issues

In New Report, ACLU Warns Against Giving Private Companies Centralized Access to Police Data

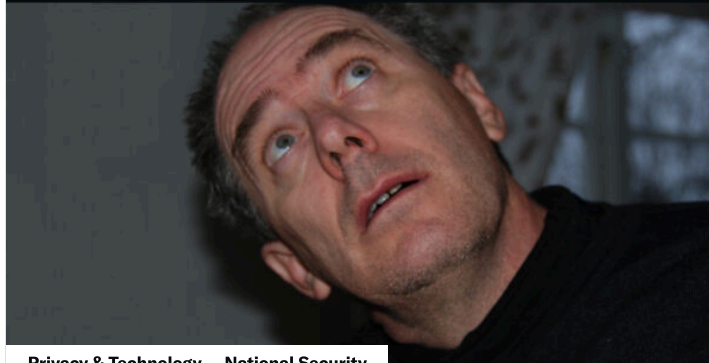
WASHINGTON – The American Civil Liberties Union (ACLU) released a new report today about the increasingly central role that surveillance and tech companies are playing in US police departments and how that threatens to give private companies unfettered access to Americans' sensitive data. The report examines the major companies involved, the potential ways this information could be abused or exploited, and the history of close ties between corporations and police. Every day, police across the country use body cameras, drones, dash cams, and fixed surveillance cameras gathering hours upon hours of footage of people going about their daily lives. And now, some of the biggest surveillance tech companies, including Axon, Flock, and Motorola, want to gather, analyze, and control this data by providing "operating systems" for police departments that, like operating systems on computers and phones, can see and control all the data in the system. This will threaten the civil rights and civil liberties of everyone who interacts with one of these cameras — knowingly or not. Part of this trend is the movement towards police cloud services, which facilitates the consolidation of data from thousands of U.S. police departments within corporate servers and gives these private actors live remote control over the surveillance tech even after it's deployed in communities. Or as Axon puts it on their website, "integrating hardware devices and cloud software solutions" in "the Axon ecosystem" and connecting "every officer, responder and agency." "Putting private, for-profit companies at the heart of modern police departments — what could go wrong? The answer is: plenty, and that's what this paper outlines" said Jay Stanley, senior policy analyst with the ACLU's Speech, Privacy and Technology Project. "Policymakers, the public, and the policing profession need to grapple with the implications of this corporatization of police departments — especially for people's civil rights and liberties — and address it before this becomes normalized and leads to new forms of abuse we've never seen before." These new corporate efforts to expand their work with police are especially worrying given how quickly surveillance technology is proliferating across the country — and how few places have strong guardrails or oversight in place. As the report details, there are many ways providers could exploit their insider access to this data, including using it to go after critics, journalists, labor unions, regulators, and competitors, or to try and fend off investigations into their products. The lack of safeguards also means that company employees could use this data to target exes, manipulate prediction markets, or even alter evidence. Unfortunately, it's not just the companies selling these products that the public needs to be worried about. According to the report, there is another set of players that raise many of the same concerns about private

companies' access to police data and the corporate role in policing: cloud computing platforms like Amazon Web Services (AWS), Microsoft Azure, and Google Cloud Platform, which currently also have access to the growing mountain of data generated by surveillance-based policing. The report lays out six recommendations that policymakers could implement to protect their constituents. Recommendations include contract requirements restricting private vendors' access to law enforcement data, mandating the use of local rather than cloud services, and passing both the Fourth Amendment Is Not For Sale Act and Community Control Over Police Surveillance (CCOPS) laws.

News & Commentary

Jun 2026

Free FUTURE



Privacy & Technology National Security

The Downsides of "Deterrence"

Surveillance Boosters Tout the Benefits of Deterrence, But There's a Big Problem With That

By: Jay Stanley

ACLU

© 2026 American Civil Liberties Union